



THE LAST BASTION OF WILL

This India-England series offered no shortcuts — **only tests of the body and mind.** Here, grit isn't a trait; it's the price of entry.

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Sport doesn't build character; it reveals it — but only in Test cricket does it leave it bruised, stitched, and interrogated over five days of ordeal.

Across five matches between India and England this summer, character was exposed in ways that T20 scarcely permits and one-dayers barely accommodate. The collisions were not just between bat and ball but between sinew and will, frailty and fight. **If this series is remembered for its moments of high skill, it will endure for the sight of broken bodies refusing to bow.**

Rishabh Pant came out on the second morning at Old Trafford with a broken foot. The previous day, a full toss from Chris Woakes had



cannoned into his right boot mid-reverse sweep. He peeled off his sock to reveal a lump that would've made a physio wince. Carted off in a buggy and sent for scans, Pant's participation in the match seemed over. Yet the next morning, he limped out, launched Jofra Archer for six, completed his half-century, and carried India beyond 350. Pain wasn't ignored; it was absorbed.

At Lord's, it was Shoaib Bashir who played through a broken finger on his left hand, clobbered by a return drive from Ravindra Jadeja. He held on for the final day, then delivered the decisive blow, dismissing Mohammed Siraj to give England a 2-1 lead. He did not bowl again in the series.

But if Lord's was England's, it was only just